

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete Sicilian Defense

A family map of major systems, structures, breaks, and Black's counterplay

TRAINING WORKBOOK

30 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. Najdorf Starting Position



02 - Najdorf Systems

POSITION PROMPT

Black prevents Nb5, keeps the e-pawn flexible, and prepares queenside expansion from an intentionally compact position.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Najdorf English Attack



02 - Najdorf Systems

POSITION PROMPT

White builds Be3-f3-Qd2 for long castling while Black fixes the center with ...e5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e5 7. Nb3 Be6 8. f3

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. Najdorf 6.Bg5 Main Line



02 - Najdorf Systems

POSITION PROMPT

White pins the f6-knight and builds e5 pressure while Black develops behind a Scheveningen center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Bg5 e6 7. f4 Be7 8. Qf3 Qc7 9. O-O-O Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Najdorf 6.Be3 with ...e5



02 - Najdorf Systems

POSITION PROMPT

Black gains central space with ...e5 and accepts a long-term contest over d5.

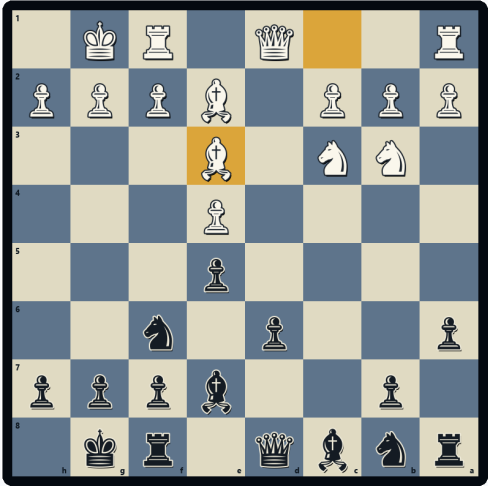
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e5 7. Nb3 Be6 8. f3 Be7 9. Qd2 O-O

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

05. Najdorf Classical 6.Be2



02 - Najdorf Systems

POSITION PROMPT

White castles short and emphasizes central control rather than an immediate pawn race.

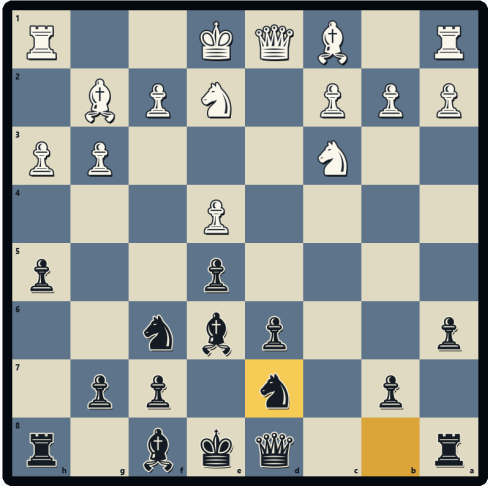
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. Be3

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

06. Najdorf 6.h3



02 - Najdorf Systems

POSITION PROMPT

White keeps several setups available while preventing ...Ng4 and preparing g4 or a quieter center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. h3 e5 7. Nde2 h5 8. g3 Be6 9. Bg2 Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. Dragon Yugoslav Attack



03 - Dragon Systems

POSITION PROMPT

Opposite-side castling creates a forcing race between White's h-pawn attack and Black's c-file pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 g6 6. Be3 Bg7 7. f3 O-O 8. Qd2 Nc6 9. O-O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

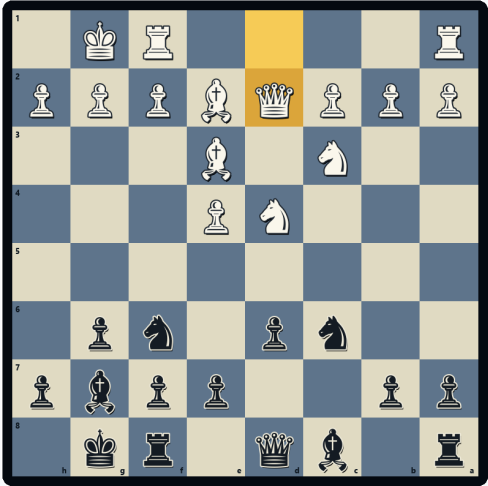
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. Dragon Classical System



03 - Dragon Systems

POSITION PROMPT

White castles short and builds central control while Black obtains the long g7 diagonal.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 g6 6. Be2 Bg7 7. O-O O-O 8. Be3 Nc6 9. Qd2

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. Accelerated Dragon Maroczy Bind



03 - Dragon Systems

POSITION PROMPT

White's c4-e4 bind restrains ...d5 but leaves long-term dark-square and pawn targets.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 g6 5. c4 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

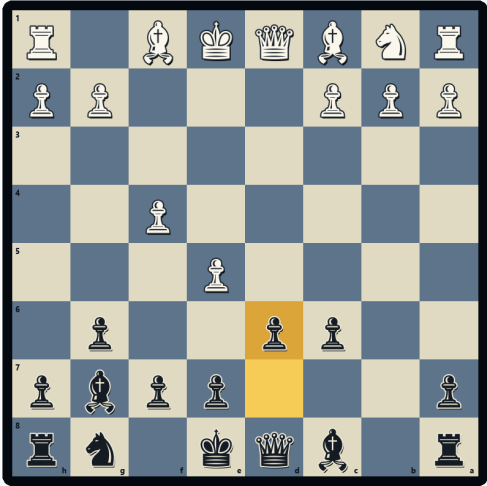
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- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. Accelerated Dragon Exchange on c6



03 - Dragon Systems

POSITION PROMPT

White damages the c-pawns but gives Black open files and central targets.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 g6 5. Nxc6 bxc6 6. e5 Bg7 7. f4 d6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

11. Hyper-Accelerated Dragon



03 - Dragon Systems

POSITION PROMPT

Black fianchettoes before committing the queen knight and invites a Maroczy structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 g6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Bg7 5. c4 Nc6 6. Be3 Nf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

12. Classical Richter-Rauzer



04 - Classical and Scheveningen

POSITION PROMPT

White pins, castles long, and builds central pressure while Black develops naturally with ...Nc6.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Nc6 6. Bg5 e6 7. Qd2 Be7 8. O-O-O O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Classical Sozin



04 - Classical and Scheveningen

POSITION PROMPT

The bishop points at e6 and f7 while Black uses a compact Scheveningen center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Nc6 6. Bc4 e6 7. Be3 Be7 8. Bb3 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

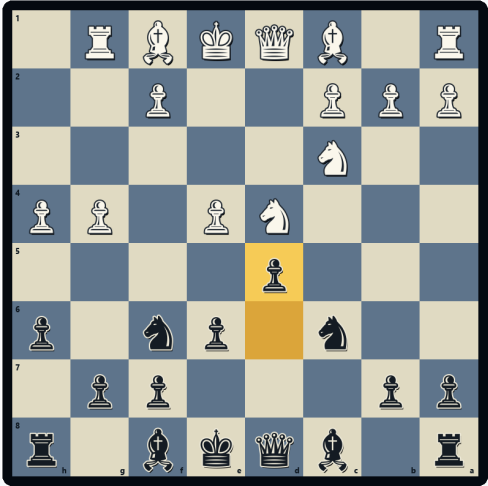
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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Scheveningen Keres Attack



04 - Classical and Scheveningen

POSITION PROMPT

White gains kingside space immediately while Black strikes in the center before castling.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 d6 6. g4 h6 7. h4 Nc6 8. Rg1 d5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

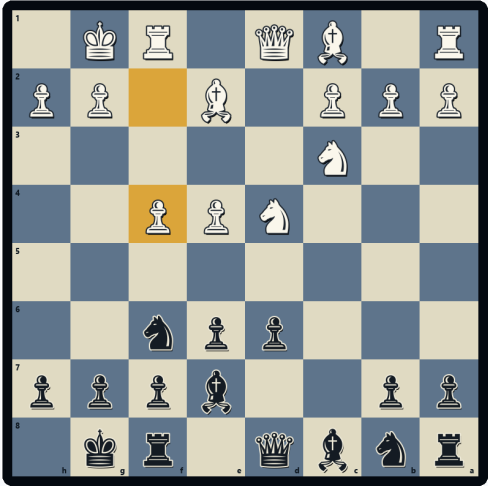
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Scheveningen Classical



04 - Classical and Scheveningen

POSITION PROMPT

Both sides develop normally before White expands with f4 and Black seeks queenside or central counterplay.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 d6 6. Be2 Be7 7. O-O O-O 8. f4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Taimanov Main Line



05 - Taimanov Kan and Four Knights

POSITION PROMPT

Black keeps both central pawn choices available and uses ...Qc7 to support flexible development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Taimanov English Attack



05 - Taimanov Kan and Four Knights

POSITION PROMPT

White castles long while Black develops the dark bishop actively instead of copying a Najdorf setup.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Kan Maroczy Structure



05 - Taimanov Kan and Four Knights

POSITION PROMPT

White occupies c4 and e4 while Black uses ...a6 and piece pressure instead of an early ...d6.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 a6 5. c4 Nf6 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd3 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

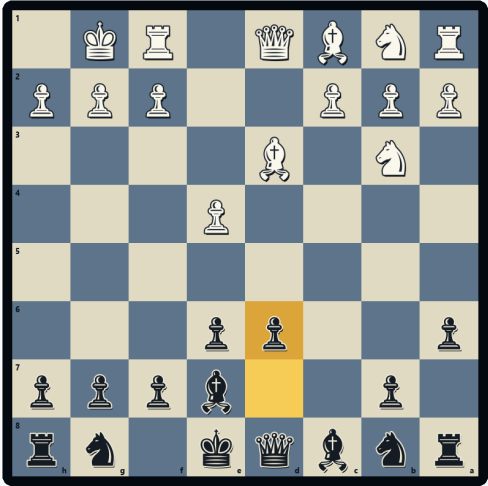
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Kan 5.Bd3 System



05 - Taimanov Kan and Four Knights

POSITION PROMPT

White develops quickly while Black gains flexible queenside control and avoids committing the b8-knight.

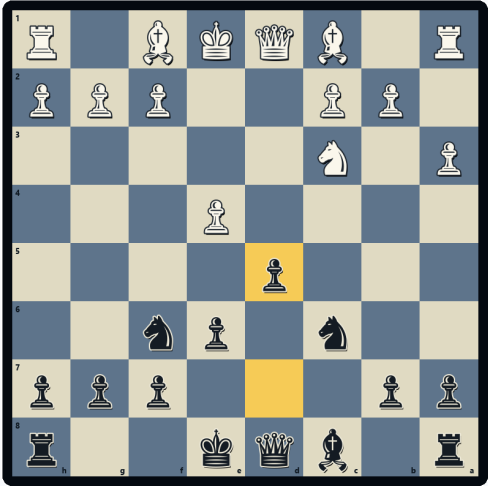
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 a6 5. Bd3 Bc5 6. Nb3 Be7 7. O-O d6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
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-

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

20. Four Knights Sicilian



05 - Taimanov Kan and Four Knights

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops both knights and meets White's Nb5 pressure with active central play.

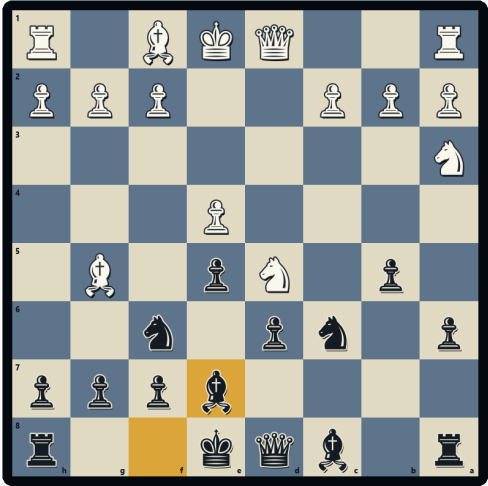
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Nc6 6. Ndb5 Bb4 7. a3 Bxc3+ 8. Nxc3 d5

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

21. Sveshnikov Main Tabiya



06 - Sveshnikov and Kalashnikov

POSITION PROMPT

Black accepts the d5 outpost and backward d6-pawn in exchange for space, tempi, and active piece play.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5 9. Nd5 Be7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

22. Sveshnikov 9.Bxf6



06 - Sveshnikov and Kalashnikov

POSITION PROMPT

Black accepts doubled f-pawns to obtain the bishop pair, the g-file, and immediate ...f5 play.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5 9. Bxf6 gxf6 10. Nd5 f5

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

23. Kalashnikov Maroczy Setup



06 - Sveshnikov and Kalashnikov

POSITION PROMPT

Black gains e5 space without ...Nf6 and allows White a c4 bind with a knight on b5.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 e5 5. Nb5 d6 6. c4 Be7 7. N1c3 a6 8. Na3

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

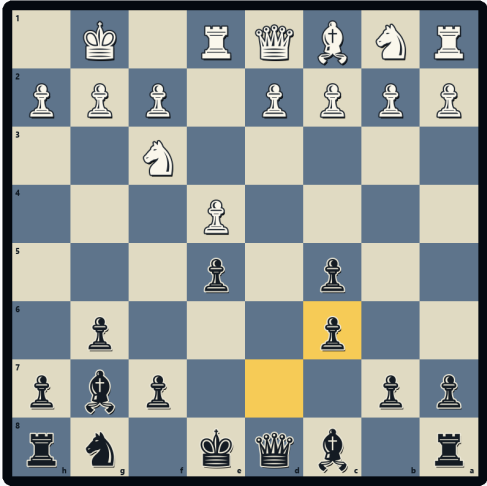
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5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

24. Rossolimo with ...g6



07 - Anti-Sicilians

POSITION PROMPT

White gives up the bishop to alter Black's queenside while Black builds a strong dark-square center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 g6 4. O-O Bg7 5. Re1 e5 6. Bxc6 dxc6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

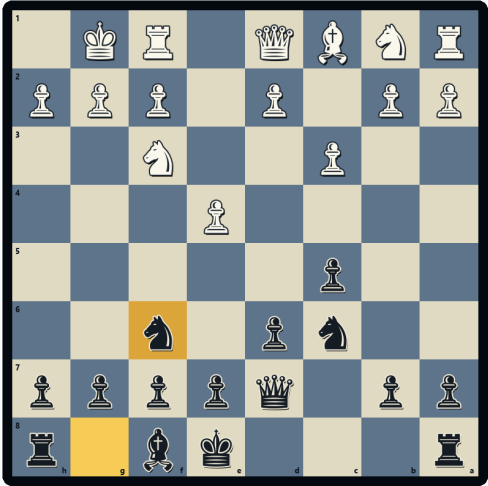
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

25. Moscow Variation



07 - Anti-Sicilians

POSITION PROMPT

Black accepts a bishop trade and develops the queen to keep a healthy structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. Bb5+ Bd7 4. Bxd7+ Qxd7 5. O-O Nc6 6. c3 Nf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

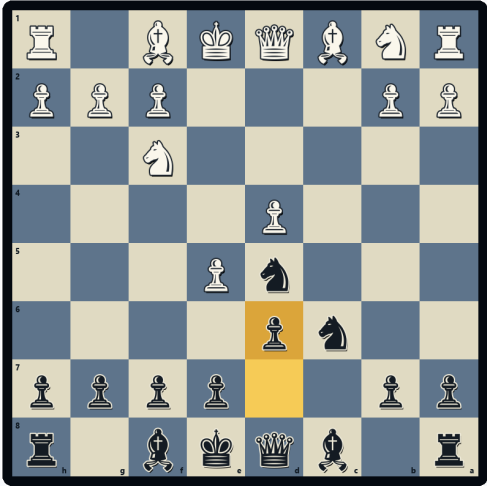
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

26. Alapin 2.c3



07 - Anti-Sicilians

POSITION PROMPT

White builds a classical center while Black attacks it before it stabilizes.

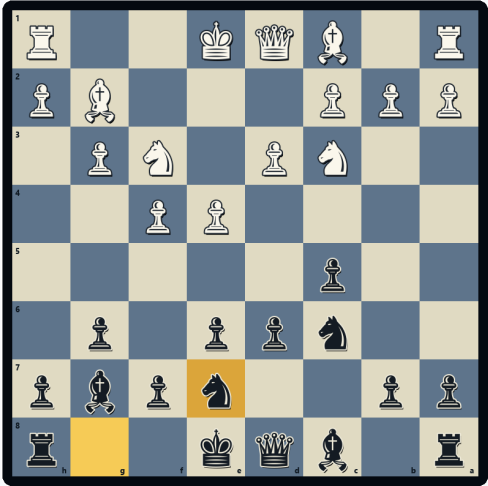
REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nf6 3. e5 Nd5 4. d4 cxd4 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. cxd4 d6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

27. Closed Sicilian



07 - Anti-Sicilians

POSITION PROMPT

White keeps the center closed and builds a kingside attack while Black has time for queenside expansion.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 Nc6 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 d6 6. f4 e6 7. Nf3 Nge7

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

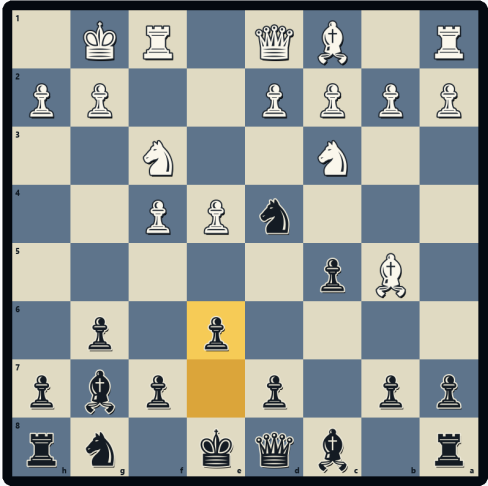
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

28. Grand Prix Attack



07 - Anti-Sicilians

POSITION PROMPT

White develops quickly for f5 and kingside pressure while Black uses the dark-square fianchetto.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 Nc6 3. f4 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Bb5 Nd4 6. O-O e6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

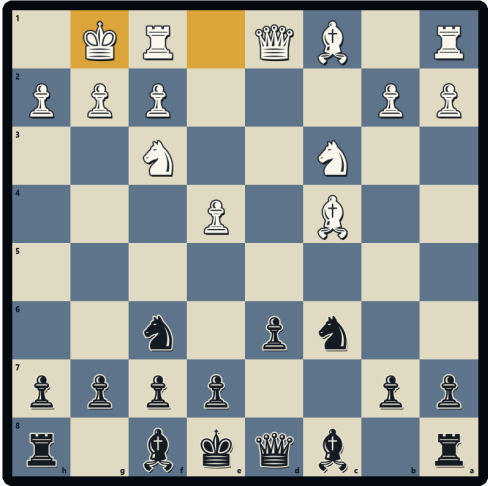
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

29. Smith-Morra Gambit Accepted



07 - Anti-Sicilians

POSITION PROMPT

Black accepts a pawn while White receives open lines and rapid development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 d6 6. Bc4 Nf6 7. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

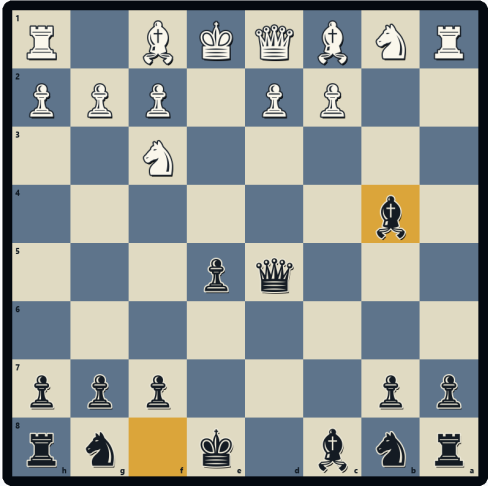
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

30. Wing Gambit



07 - Anti-Sicilians

POSITION PROMPT

White offers the b-pawn to divert Black's c-pawn and accelerate central development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. b4 cxb4 3. a3 d5 4. exd5 Qxd5 5. Nf3 e5 6. axb4 Bxb4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.